

KF24 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

Please join with us by circulating your gifts. You can make a regular automatic donation through the KF website.

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This week we will start learning another meditation practice. Our goal in this part of the meeting is simply to introduce different mindfulness and meditation techniques. During your meditation time, you can use a variety of practices, or you can choose one practice to suit your present need and state of mind. The meditation masters encourage us to stick with one method for a few years, and we can understand their reasons, but for the rest of this year, you might just practice the meditation of the month and explore what works for you. In this lesson we will look at a meditation practice called **Centering Prayer**, popularized by Father Thomas Keating.¹

In the **Centering Prayer** pamphlet, we read:

Centering Prayer is a method of silent prayer that prepares us to receive the gift of contemplative prayer, prayer in which we experience God's presence within us, closer than breathing, closer than thinking, closer than consciousness itself. This method of prayer is both a relationship with God and a discipline to foster that relationship.²

Centering Prayer

Begin with stillness, resting in your spirit and your natural breath. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause)* To straighten your neck, lift the back of your head and lower your chin a little. Reach the crown of your head toward the heavens and your tailbone toward the earth. You might try standing during this meditation time, which may help focus a wandering mind. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, try asking God for a word, a phrase, or an image. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* We will use the simple term *word* to refer to these words, phrases, and images. Some people identify a word like *love*, *mercy*, or *Jesus* or a meaningful image—for example, a waterfall or a bird in flight. You might choose a word of guidance like *let go* or *connect*. Allow your word to float to the surface of your consciousness and stick to it during

the meditation time. When other thoughts intrude into your consciousness, gently return to your word. Breathe, and allow your mind to rest in stillness as you continue to recall the word. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

When you are comfortable with your word, try allowing it to float away from your mind. Dwell in the silence and rest in the stillness as you simply observe your breathing. You might attend to the word for one breath and then allow your mind to repose silently for two breaths. We will practice for one minute. Remember to consciously breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

During this last minute of meditation, we will let go of the word completely and allow our minds to rest in stillness as we observe the breath. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Take a fresh, deep breath as if you were stretching your insides. Gently open your eyes and re-engage with your environment.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we will turn our attention to KF Confession 6:

We chose to foster illusions to save the life of our Idol Self.

Before we get started with our Toolbox training, you might want to take out a **Two Paths Worksheet**. You will also need this worksheet for the Bible Teaching.

When you look at the **Two Paths Worksheet: Believing v. Judging**, perhaps you can see how far you have come in your training. This worksheet reminds us of how we used to live, with all of our stories, reactions, and mindlessness.

I would like to review how self-hate works. You might wonder why I keep talking about it. I keep talking about it because self-hate, not love, makes the world go round; and the more you understand self-hate, the better off you will be. Through training hard, we learn to manage our own self-hate more efficiently, and we also learn to spot and manage with compassion the self-hate of others. We can learn to immediately take the Believe It Path when we are confronted with the chaos of self-hate. Generating self-hate is the function of the Idol Self. To achieve its purposes, the Idol not only develops patterns of behavior that generate self-hate but also behaviors that defuse our self-hate. We now understand that self-hate, and the compelling drive to escape self-hate, is really what motivates most people. People living in the Idol's system are numb and atrophied, so they need a strong motivator, and the fear of self-hate does the job. If a person does not understand or practice love, no other means of motivation is available to them. Self-hate is such a powerful motivator that most people would feel lost, confused, and worthless without it. These feelings are so scary that people will not give up their self-hate without a fight.

One day a woman who had been working with me for a few weeks called with a problem. She did not know whether she should sit down or stand up. Her ability to make her own decisions and her capacity for self-determination had gradually atrophied over the years, and she had learned to motivate herself with shoulds and the fear of self-hate. Whenever she was presented with a choice, even between good

options, she felt the sting of hurt pride. She had a claim that she should never be bothered with making choices, even if those choices invited her to express her own preferences. In her search for an idealized life of freedom, she had lost her free will. Through KF training, her self-hate has begun to lose its grip. She is no longer focused on fulfilling her shoulds and claims, and her self-worth is less dependent on situations and outcomes that support her pride and her search for glory. She has started to exercise a little free will and is now able to make a few authentic choices. Although she often feels lost, inadequate, and confused by the options open to her, she has begun to strengthen the atrophied muscle of her free will.

If we choose to live in the Idol's pride system, we will not be motivated to grow our love and joy, pursue peace, and develop the qualities of gentleness, self-management, and trustworthiness—in other words, we will not be interested in producing the Fruit of the Spirit in our lives; we will be motivated by our search for glory and driven to maintain an artificial and legalistic state of being. Maintaining our pride system takes a lot of work and uses up tons of our precious energy, but it's work that we are used to. Powerful fear drives us, and we are lured into the hunter's snare by the illusion that adhering to our pride system will save our lives.³ Simply recognizing our fear can give us a moment to breathe rather than immediately reacting to an event. Once we admit that our pride is powerless to deliver us from the grip of fear, we can choose the path of orientation. We can start defusing the chaotic feelings of self-hate with W-A-A! (Words, Attitude, Action) and other KF tools.⁴ Use the **Two Paths Flowchart** regularly to look at what is happening in your life, and allow yourself a moment to breathe before you act.

Now let's review the **Two Paths Worksheet: Believing v. Judging**. You can actually start anywhere on this worksheet, but in this lesson we will begin with step 1, the outcome.

1. **OUTCOME: What am I experiencing?**

You will find this step under the Judgment Path. It's often helpful to begin by exploring your outcome because most of the time you don't know what led to that outcome. Perhaps your outcome is linked to a repeated pattern of addictive or compulsive behaviors. What are you experiencing right now? You might ask yourself: *Is my outcome demonstrating the love of God and supporting His purposes in this world? Does the outcome support my personal growth, the growth of another, or the growth of a relationship?* If not, you are probably on the Judgment Path.

2. **ACTION: What did I do or avoid that invited this outcome?**

When you have observed the outcome, you can use the worksheet to trace your outcome back to its source. What choice did you make or what action did you take that led to the outcome? Or did you avoid a courageous choice or action?

3. **REJOICING IN THE MISORIENTATION: What emotions did I experience that drove me to act?**

The idea that you have rejoiced in misorientation can be difficult to understand at first. Misoriented emotions drive misoriented choices, so you might ask yourself: *Did I indulge in some kind of vindictive triumph? Did I delight in euphoria through self-indulgence or recklessness? Did I get caught up in illusions about myself or others? Did I relieve my tension in a rage to conclude? Did I act out of self-hate or the fear of hurt pride?* It is hard to imagine that we actually rejoice in feeling unhealthy and unproductive emotions, but we do. These misoriented emotions are the sparks that we need to ignite the self-hate engine that drives our rage to conclude. So, just list the emotions that motivated your choice. The lists of emotions on the other KF worksheets might help you identify what you are feeling.

4. **THE STORY: What story did I tell that generated emotions?**

Human beings are creative; we are designed to tell stories. The Idol Self hijacks that natural ability and uses storytelling to create an alternate reality. We can use our imagination to make up stories about why a particular situation is good or bad, but that is not how God intended us to use this creative gift. We all have a story about why we are the way we are, do what we do, think what we think, and feel what we feel. Our stories justify our judgments, fuel our misoriented emotions, and support our pride system.

5. JUDGING AS GOOD OR EVIL: What was my short-tempered judgment?

What was your automatic reaction to the event or situation? Did you judge it as good or bad?

6. FEAR OF DEATH OR EUPHORIA: What standard of my Idol Self was threatened or fulfilled?

You might ask yourself: *What was dangerous or delirious about this event? How did it threaten or fulfill my search for an imagined glory?* You may now recognize what scared you or what, perhaps, relieved you of your fear of death.

You can learn to notice when the pressure of self-hate is building up in your self-hate cylinders. If you want to be able to choose how you react when sparks start to fly, you will have to prevent the build-up of self-hate fumes. Otherwise, those sparks will ignite the pressurized self-hate that has built up in your engine, and you will end up spending your precious energy clearing up the mess—a mess that may be irreparable. It takes more energy to clear up a mess than it does to train regularly and avoid the build-up the first place. Learn to smell the fumes early. Rather than waiting for the explosion, learn to sense when pressure, or tension, is mounting. You can then defuse that tension with your tools. Tension, or strain, is your signal to turn back to the Believe It Path. You can turn before you burn your life.

When you feel tension or strain, you might do a **Shoulds Sheet** or a **Claim and Blame Worksheet**. Practice mindfulness daily so that you are aware of what is going on inside you. Explore the **T-A-T** and use the **Tapping Protocol** regularly.⁵ Call a KF friend. This is especially necessary for resigned types who habitually avoid dealing with what is going on in themselves. When we are more consciously connected with ourselves, we can sense the times when we are disconnecting under the tension. We can then deal with the beam in our own eye before we act.

After you have worked through steps 1–6, choose an intervention to help you gain more clarity about your reactions. You might wish to use the **Tapping Protocol**, mindfulness practices, or our next tool, the **T-A-T**, which we will explore in our next lesson.⁶ Then, use your creative imagination in an oriented way as you work up the left side of the worksheet, taking the Believe It Path.

7. EVENT: What triggered the fear or the euphoria?

Perhaps at this stage you are able to identify what ignited the fuel in the cylinders of your self-hate engine or temporarily fulfilled your idealized dreams of glory. What happened that sent you down the Judgment Path? Try to describe the event simply.

As you work through steps 8–12, use the beautiful gift of your imagination in a healthy way to help you take the Believe It Path and plan a course that could create an opportunity for oriented, productive outcomes.

8. LOVE BELIEVES: What might be a long-tempered response?

At this stage in your KF training, you might be able to move away from judgment based on fear and imagine the other options now available to you. You might simply stand; you might speak your reality

moderately; you might do a worksheet or an intervention; or you might just breathe before addressing the event.

9. STORY: What are the simple facts about what happened?

If you were to purge judgments and emotions from your story, what would your story look like? Simply list in sequence the incidents that led to the event.

10. REJOICING IN THE TRUTH: What does this event teach me about myself or others?

Is there anything that you can learn about your own need for training or about the trustworthiness of others? Can you identify what works and what doesn't? What can this event teach you about God, yourself, or your world? If you were to set aside your fear, pride, and judgment, what positive possibilities might this event present?

11. ACTION: What choices can I make based on truth?

As you focus on only what is real, what choices and actions might inject love into the situation? How can you turn a seemingly negative situation into a positive learning experience? In what way might you lean on the Lord and not on your own understanding?

12. OUTCOME: What are the possibilities?

If you were to respond to the event without judgment and without compulsive reactions, what outcomes would be possible?

If someone else was involved in your event, you might ask if they would allow you to go through the scene again together, taking the Believe It Path. My husband and I call this *rewinding*. We rewind the security tapes and shoot the scene again guided by the Believe It Path. This retrains our neuropaths and, also, places us in a position of humility where we find God's grace. If we go through the scene again, we can repattern our responses for positive outcomes and learn how to make oriented choices in the future when faced with similar situations.

You already know that extreme outbursts, irritations, anxieties, self-sabotage, hurts, depression, forcing things, and shutting down are all symptoms of the self-hate that drives each of us back into slavery to the Idol. But you really can look at self-hate with compassion even when you are feeling its compelling invitations. You can courageously observe what is going on, learn to manage yourself, and, eventually, grow out of self-hate.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Holy Spirit, guide me to defuse the power of my self-hate. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's listen once again to KF Confession 6:

We chose to foster illusions to save the life of our Idol Self.

This month we will look at our illusions about life, others, and ourselves—illusions that we ferociously defend in order to protect our pride. In the midst of our anxiety and chaotic choices, we have learned to depend on our pride as a substitute for real self-confidence. When things fall apart, we get a marvelous chance to examine our pride and our attachments.

In our last lesson, we learned in the Gospel of John that God loved us so much that He sent His Son, not to judge us, but to rescue us. Our karis response is to come to the light so that we can see what we are actually doing—what is real. In the next passage, John gives us an example of coming to the light. We will look at this event in the lives of John the Baptist's disciples and examine it through the lens of the **Two Paths Worksheet**. Here is my paraphrase of **John 3:22–30**.

²²After these things Jesus and his disciples went into the land of Judea, and He was spending time with them and baptizing (which is symbolic of purification). ²³John was also baptizing in Aenon near Salim since there was lots of water there, and people were coming to be baptized. ²⁴This was before John had been thrown into prison. ²⁵In the midst of this baptizing, John's disciples initiated a discussion with a Jew about purification. ²⁶Then they came to John and said to him, "Rabbi, He who was with you on the other side of the Jordan, the one that you endorsed—just look at Him! He is baptizing and all are coming to Him." ²⁷John answered and said, "No one is capable of receiving anything like purification unless it is granted to them from heaven. So, it really doesn't matter who they go to for purification. ²⁸By the way, you yourselves can endorse me—I have already told you that I, myself, am not the Christ, but that I have been sent ahead of Him. ²⁹The same principle of purification applies to marriage rites. It's not about the one who does the purifying but about the one who has the bride—that is, the bridegroom. The friend of the bridegroom who stands by and hears him greatly rejoices in the bridegroom's voice because he is not envious or desiring his place. Therefore, my mission as friend is completed, and this makes me full of joy. ³⁰The bridegroom is the one who must be brought to manhood, and I, myself, must recede from the scene."

Take a deep breath.

To give us a deeper understanding of this story, we will now use the **Two Paths Worksheet**. We can start with step 7 because this passage describes the event. We will follow John's disciples as they take the Judgment Path, and we will see that at step 2, the point of action, these well-trained disciples apply what they have learned: they switch paths, get creative, and make an oriented choice.

7. EVENT: What triggered the fear or the euphoria?

Jesus is becoming more popular than John, whose ministry is declining. In this passage, we see one event but two very different reactions to that event. Out of fear and pride, John's disciples judge the event as bad. John the Baptist, on the other hand, believes the event and trusts in his design and mission. How is it that John takes the Believe It Path, but his disciples take the Judgment Path?

We see that the disciples are already suffering. When they recognized that Jesus' ministry was more popular than John's, their fear and judgment began building up fuel in the cylinders of their self-hate engine. Jesus's growing popularity threatened their personal search for glory and their sense of security. They then tried to assert their authority by discussing purification practices with a Jew.

Arguing about the rights and wrongs of religious practice and beliefs is one of the Idol's devices for igniting our self-hate cylinders. Can you see how fragile the Idol Self is? If anyone holds another belief, the Idol must fight or flee. It cannot peacefully explore and learn.

6. FEAR OF DEATH OR EUPHORIA: What standard of my Idol Self was threatened or fulfilled?

What do the disciples fear? Are they hoping for esteem and affection because their teacher is popular? Are they looking for power and control? Are some of them attaching themselves to a spiritual person so that they can feel spiritual without doing any of the hard work themselves? They may be desiring security and survival. They are obviously in a rage to conclude the tension created by their leader's declining influence. They want John to do something. We don't know exactly what they fear, but John's disciples suddenly see their search for glory disappearing into the mist, and they feel anxious. The imagined outcomes that they hoped to gain by following John are not getting actualized! Their Idol's life is threatened, and they are seeking to relieve their tension.

5. JUDGING AS GOOD OR EVIL: What was my short-tempered judgment?

We have been conditioned to judge as evil any event that triggers our fear. In this passage, we see that the disciples judge as bad the decline of their ministry.

4. STORY: What story did I tell that generated emotions?

John's disciples seem to be judging Jesus and blaming John. Perhaps they hate themselves because they think that they should be able to know it all, convince others effortlessly, and attract the crowds by their spiritual superiority. Their pride is invested in their own way of doing and understanding things, and their investment is now threatened. The disciples see their search for glory slipping away from them, and they feel the threat of self-hate. Rather than looking at their own motives and illusions, they make up a story. They escape their tension by blaming and judging someone else.

When we fail to live up to our secret standards, we often need to hold someone else responsible. I don't know exactly what story the disciples imagined that blamed others for their distress, but here are some possibilities: *Jesus is taking people away from us and making us look like nobodies. This is John's fault; he should assert himself more.* At a deep level, some of these disciples may be thinking: *I'm an idiot for choosing John. I'm not doing a good enough job. My system isn't working.* Whatever the story might be, they are certainly thinking: *This is so unfair!*

3. REJOICING IN THE MISORIENTATION: What emotions did I experience that drove me to act?

The story that we tell ourselves can generate a whole range of emotions. The disciples may be feeling anxiety over their limitations, frustration because they *should* be able to change the situation, dismay or embarrassment about their leader's decreasing popularity, or wrath and indignation because the situation is *unfair*. They are rejoicing in misoriented emotions that support their wobbling pride.

11. ACTION: What choices can I make based on the truth?

At this point, John's disciples switch from step 2 on the Judgment Path to step 11 on the Believe It Path. The emotions generated by their story invited them to take misoriented action, but now the quality of their training becomes evident. These disciples respond to their self-hate in a healthy way. They are willing to explore the Believe It Path, and they take action by talking to their teacher. They have chosen to follow John, so we know that they are the kind of people who choose to have a teacher in their lives. They have positioned themselves to be trained to live in a new way. They have invested a great deal of time and resources to turn their lives toward the light. They tell their teacher their story. Even though they may appear to be whining, they are at least engaging their teacher in a

conversation which may reveal to them another perspective. We don't know if they all adopted John's perspective, but they at least gave themselves the opportunity to do so.

In this material world, we live on a timeline, so when we take a misoriented action, we cannot go back and undo the damage we have done; we have passed the point of no return. Misoriented actions always produce misoriented outcomes, and misoriented actions are the result of misoriented emotions. However, if we can recognize and humbly admit that our emotions are misoriented, we can choose to take oriented action instead of continuing down the Judgment Path and creating a mess. We can redirect our misoriented trail of cause and effect toward orientation.

Now look at John's response to his declining popularity. John takes the Believe It Path; he is a person of no fear. He has trained hard. His fight is easy. He too sees what is happening, but he chooses faith, or trust, in God. He believes rather than judges. John has known all along what his job is, what is *his business*. Without the emotional turmoil generated by judgment, he simply believes the fact that the crowds are going to Jesus. Rather than trying to defend hurt pride, he rejoices in the truth of who God designed him to be and what God designed him to do. He experiences the secure confidence of having completed his mission. He feels joy over the rise of Jesus and can embrace his own decline in popularity because he is not attached to an idealized outcome based on the illusion of personal superiority. He knows that he is not the Christ. His action is to let go and rest. I think that we can hear in John's voice the sense of satisfaction and release. He can let go because he knows that in his True Self he has fulfilled his design and mission. His work in this particular area is now complete, and he can trust God to guide him to the next step.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, when things fall apart, guide me into believing it and trusting You. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some clean water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a time when you were not or were no longer valued. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you consider a time when you were not or were no longer valued, how does it feel? (Pause) Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold this experience in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush real feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us and stretch us. Observe your thoughts and feelings without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider this time of not being valued*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* You might recognize what rage or abandonment feels like in your body. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to another area of the body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider not being valued*. Jesus knows what that feels like. *(Pause)* Do you judge not being valued by others as good or evil? *(Pause)* What do you believe when you see or feel that you are not valued? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created all of us to have these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have had very strong feelings when they were not or were no longer valued. We all know what that feels like. *(Pause)* When these feelings are triggered, you can breathe rather than reacting and allowing yourself to get caught up in stories. You can let go of managing God's business. Breathe, and extend compassion to yourself and others in this situation. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time together to train and to heal. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our real glory and to the truth about who we are and what You would have us do. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and mission, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ www.centeringprayer.com.

² Ibid.

³ See KF12.

⁴ See KF16.

⁵ Dr. Roger Callahan, "TFT Stress Buster Tapping Class-Learn to Use TFT Tapping," Callahan Techniques, accessed April 24, 2016, www.rogercallahan.com/learn-to-tap.php. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven; en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tapas_Acupressure_Technique.

⁶ Dr. Roger Callahan, "TFT Stress Buster Tapping Class-Learn to Use TFT Tapping," Callahan Techniques, accessed April 24, 2016, www.rogercallahan.com/learn-to-tap.php. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven; en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tapas_Acupressure_Technique.